VOL. 1 · NO. 35 PRINTED FOR DANIEL PRICE: ONE CUP OF COFFEE

The Morning Newspaper

WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 21, 2026 · AUSTIN EDITION

84° / 52° | Clear, 0% rain, wind up to 7 mph | Tomorrow: 85° / 59°, overcast | Sunrise 7:37 · Sunset 18:53 | Waxing gibbous

Musk floats merging SpaceX and Tesla into a company worth over $3 trillion

Special committees at both companies are now studying a tie-up, and traders bid up both stocks well before any deal is signed.

Stocks drifted higher, with the S&P 500 and Nasdaq extending their recovery from last week's AI-driven selloff as the VIX eased back toward 17. The day's real action was in Musk's orbit: SpaceX-tracking shares SPCX leapt more than 9% and Tesla gained over 3% on word that both companies have formed committees to study a merger that would fold rockets, cars and AI into a single entity worth well north of $3 trillion. Meta added another 2% on continuing AI-infrastructure optimism, while Alphabet slid nearly 2.5%, the market's biggest loser among megacaps. Bitcoin pushed above $84,000 and the 10-year yield eased slightly, both consistent with investors treating this week's PHP vulnerability scare and tariff noise as background rather than a reason to de-risk.

WORLD & TECH

PHP patches two critical flaws after AI-assisted discovery

ARS TECHNICA · TECHMEME / WALL STREET JOURNAL

PHP shipped emergency fixes for a pair of unauthenticated remote-code-execution bugs, dubbed "PHP2Shell," that researchers say could touch up to 70% of the web's servers. OpenAI, Wiz and Quarkslab found the flaws using an AI model over the summer, and Cloudflare quietly rolled out default WAF protections for all customers hours before the public disclosure. Site operators on PHP 8.2 through 8.5 are being told to patch immediately.

Russia frees American Stephen Hubbard without a swap

BBC · THE NEW YORK TIMES

The 74-year-old former teacher, held for more than three years, was released as Trump's envoy Steve Witkoff met Vladimir Putin in St Petersburg. Trump called it a goodwill gesture rather than a negotiated exchange, though it costs Putin, who is wanted for war crimes, little.

Trump's approval rating sinks to 36% before the midterms

THE GUARDIAN · NYT/SIENA POLL

A new NYT/Siena survey puts Trump at a fresh low two weeks before voters go to the polls, with disapproval concentrated on his handling of the economy and the cost of living. The same poll has likely voters favoring Democratic House candidates by 11 points.

Israeli military detains Brad Lander and dozens of olive-harvest volunteers

THE NEW YORK TIMES · THE GUARDIAN

About 80 US, Israeli and British volunteers, including New York congressional candidate Brad Lander, were detained near Nahalin in the West Bank while helping Palestinian farmers harvest olives. Lander said he was released after roughly three hours, but other volunteers remained in custody.

MARKETS

INDEX	LAST	CHG
S&P 500	7,729.66	+0.22%
Dow Jones	52,518.86	+0.04%
Nasdaq	26,588.45	+0.62%
Russell 2000	2,785.64	+0.44%
VIX	17.21	-0.58%
10-yr yield	5.10	-0.29%
CRYPTO		
Bitcoin	$84,169	+1.31%
Ethereum	$2,479.94	+0.73%
STOCKS		
NVDA	$219.47	+1.39%
AAPL	$340.27	+0.23%
MSFT	$529.25	-0.49%
GOOGL	$331.99	-2.44%
AMZN	$260.78	-0.70%
META	$708.62	+2.07%
AVGO	$334.44	+0.02%
TSLA	$385.73	+3.22%
SPCX	$161.70	+9.41%
BRK-B	$542.49	+0.49%
TSM	$427.56	+0.58%

ON THIS DAY

October 21, 1879: Thomas Edison's lab in Menlo Park successfully tested a carbonized-filament incandescent bulb that burned for more than 13 hours, the breakthrough that made practical electric lighting commercially viable.

FROM THE FEEDS · FULL TEXT IN SECTION B

LONGREADS
He Was a Suspect in the Yogurt Shop Murders for Thirty Years — an Austin man exonerated this year after decades under suspicion in the notorious case.

LONGREADS
The Man Who Taught Us How to Pay Attention — why critic John Berger's way of looking is an antidote to the age of infinite scrolling.

ASTRAL CODEX TEN
Against Against Handover — Scott Alexander pushes back on a prominent argument against ceding ground to AI systems.

NAUTILUS
Primates Also Become Germophobes After a Viral Outbreak — what monkeys that lived through an epidemic reveal about the evolution of disgust.

NAUTILUS
Are Our Hearts Strong Enough to Get to Mars? — the circulatory toll of prolonged spaceflight, and whether human bodies can take a Mars transit.

NAUTILUS
The Most Unsettling Books We Know — scientists and artists name the book that scared them to the core.

PSYCHE
Dear Al Pacino — a writer on transcribing his mother's delusional letters to celebrities, and what it cost them both.

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Sources: RSS, Open-Meteo, Yahoo Finance, CoinGecko, web

LONGREADS

He Was a Suspect in the Yogurt Shop Murders for Thirty Years. He Can't Forget.

KRISTA STEVENS · LONGREADS.COM · OCT 21, 2026

A decades-long wrongful-suspicion saga in Austin's own backyard, finally resolved this year.

Forrest Welborn had nothing to do with the Yogurt Shop Murders, the grisly killing of four young women in Austin, Texas, in 1991. His buddy, Maurice Pierce, had been under pressure to confess by investigators who wanted a collar for the crime. Eventually, Pierce caved under questioning. He implicated himself and his best friend, Forrest, along with two others, in a crime they did not commit. For Texas Monthly, Michael Hall covers the case and its horrific aftermath.

Both boys were taken to a juvenile detention center, and at around midnight, Maurice was transferred to the police station. A couple of hours later, his questioning began, directed by Senior Sergeant Hector Polanco, a fifteen-year veteran with a reputation for getting confessions. Polanco was known to walk into an interrogation room and announce that his nickname was “El Diablo”; he would threaten the death penalty and grab a man’s arm and show just where the needle would go.

Maurice was terrified. He later told his girlfriend, Kim, that Polanco had claimed that his pistol was the murder weapon—and showed him graphic photos of the dead girls. “They were throwing them in his face, saying, ‘This is how the girls look now,’ ” Kim told me. (Polanco later denied doing either of these things.) In a statement Maurice wrote later that afternoon, after several hours of questioning by Polanco, he admitted to having the gun the night of the murders but insisted he didn’t have anything to do with the crime. Instead, he claimed that Forrest had borrowed the gun, had been acting oddly (“I think he was on some kind of drugs. . . .

Continued online (full article about 316 words). Scan, or visit https://longreads.com/2026/10/21/forrest-welborn-texas-monthly/

LONGREADS

The Man Who Taught Us How to Pay Attention

BRENDAN FITZGERALD · LONGREADS.COM · OCT 20, 2026

A thoughtful look at how John Berger's criticism counters our age of infinite scrolling.

John Berger spent a meaningful portion of his life thinking, with precision and care, about how to look at the world—an effort he detailed in numerous essays and books, among them Ways of Seeing and About Looking. “Reading them, you often feel you’re standing next to him in the museum or even looking through his eyes at a painting or a sculpture,” writes A.O. Scott. “You pay attention to his attention.” Scott, an attentive reader himself, brings Berger’s lifelong project into our famously distractable era; his consideration of Berger is a primer for observation and study, a gentle nudge to focus, lest we lose sight of something essential.

Right now, we’re in the midst of an attention crisis, individually and collectively snared in an infinite scroll of disruption and distraction. Berger saw this crisis coming and foresaw its consequences. In 1978, writing about photography and its impact on the modern world, he argued that the dominance of images “creates an eternal present of immediate expectation: Memory ceases to be necessary or desirable. With the loss of memory, the continuities of meaning and judgment are also lost to us.” That diagnosis seems even truer today, as the functions of remembering, judging and interpreting are increasingly offloaded from human minds and communities into the ether of social media feeds and artificial intelligence. We’re in danger of forgetting how to look.

More essays on looking deeper

“Today, photo geeks the world over consider Paul Kwilecki a master of the documentary form.”

ASTRAL CODEX TEN

Against Against Handover

SCOTT ALEXANDER · ASTRALCODEXTEN.COM · OCT 20, 2026

Scott Alexander's technical rebuttal in a live debate over ceding ground to AI systems.

The latest bugbear is “AI successionism”, the belief that AIs should succeed humans as rulers of Earth. But some critiques fail to distinguish between two different ideas.

True successionism says that AIs should take over, killing humans or steamrolling over their interests. This is very bad: a compact description of the thing that AI safety is against.

Handoverism says that humans should prioritize their own interests, but that those interests may be well-served by having aligned AIs in positions of control.

Some people in AI safety, including me, find this latter position plausible. We are being lumped in with the true successionists as fellow travelers in an anti-human direction (1, 2, 3, although thanks for commenters pointing out that these essays do at least make the distinction).

It may seem counterintuitive that human interests can be served by having AIs in positions of control. But I think the counterintuitiveness comes from a nationalist outlook where 'the State is the highest expression of the life of a people', and the role of leadership is for someone of your own ethnic group to be the leader so you can feel good about being on top.

The liberal outlook is that the state exists to help individuals fulfill their goals. At the risk of desacralizing the state a little more than I mean to, it's a service provider, dispensing coordination, public order, redistribution, and other good things. It's fine to automate service providers. If robot garbagemen are safer and cleaner than humans, we'll eventually automate trash collection; if robot legislators provide coordination, order, etc better than we do, we should automate that too. Every vision of the utopian future agrees we will have robot servants. And the president, they tell us, is merely a public servant.



Continued online (full article about 4468 words). Scan, or visit https://www.astralcodexten.com/p/against-against-handover

NAUTILUS

Primates Also Become Germophobes After Living Through a Viral Outbreak

JAKE CURRIE · NAUTIL.US · OCT 20, 2026

Evolutionary biology on how surviving an outbreak reshapes instinctive disgust.

Remember the early days of the COVID-19 pandemic? Without having a solid handle on how the virus spread, we were left to quarantine our mail, wipe down any packages with disinfectant, and wash our produce with soap and water. According to a new study published in Royal Society Open Science, humans aren't the only primates who take extreme precautions during viral outbreaks.

In 2020, a Texas primate sanctuary was dealing with its own mini-pandemic. Simian retrovirus Type II, a virus that causes an immune deficiency similar to AIDS in primates, swept through three of four groups of Japanese macaques housed at the sanctuary. Bad news for the monkeys, but good news for cognitive scientists from the University of California San Diego. They used the natural experiment to investigate how exposure to the virus changed the behaviors of exposed groups versus the unexposed one.

The team tested 55 of the macaques, offering them a choice between fruit placed on wood (or a kitchen sponge) and fruit placed on a surface covered with real macaque feces trapped under a layer of epoxy. While this might seem like an obvious choice even without a viral outbreak, previous research has shown macaques will still eat feces-contaminated food, provided it's rewarding enough.

They found that macaques in the unexposed group ate the contaminated-appearing fruit in 79 percent of trials. In contrast, macaques from the groups that had firsthand experience with the virus only picked the feces food in 47 percent of trials—whether they had been infected or not. According to the team, this suggests that it was the experience of the outbreak itself, rather than any contact with the actual virus, that caused the behavioral change.



Continued online (full article about 616 words). Scan, or visit https://nautil.us/primates-also-become-germophobes-after-living-through-a-viral-outbreak-1285973/